Requests and Roadblocks: How Note Requests and Rating Bottlenecks Shape Which Posts Get Community Notes

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1. Project Summary

Problem. X, Meta, and TikTok now rely on crowd-sourced "community notes" alongside professional fact-checking. On X, a note appears only if raters with diverse viewpoints rate it helpful, so most proposed notes never appear and the ones that do often arrive late. Users can also *request* a note on a post, and requests are shown to experienced writers once enough accumulate. We ask two questions:

- **RQ1 (Requests: replication and extension).** Recent studies find that requests speed up note writing [Pilarski26] and shape which posts get notes [Chuai26]. Do these associations hold in the most recent public data (mid-2025 to 2026), and do requests also speed up *publication* of notes?
- **RQ2 (Failure modes).** Why do proposed notes fail to publish: because too few raters ever see them, or because raters see them and disagree? How has this changed through 2026?

Why it matters. Prior work shows that notes can reduce spread once attached [Slaughter25, Nature26], but that they may arrive too late to matter [Chuai24, Nature26]. A DDIA analysis of public data through March 2025 found over 90% of notes never published, with many stuck unrated [DDIA25]. Requests are a platform lever aimed at this bottleneck, and several recent studies examine how they steer writers' attention [Pilarski26, Chuai26, Gong26]. What those studies' abstracts leave open, and what we examine, is what happens to notes *after* they are written: whether request-linked notes get rated and whether they reach consensus. The two failure modes call for different fixes: better routing and attention if notes are under-rated, versus better note quality or algorithm design if they are rated but contested. The audience for the findings is platform designers (X's Community Notes team, Meta, TikTok), who control request routing, rating-queue prioritization, and writer incentives, plus fact-checking organizations deciding where to focus effort.

2. Related Work (draft)

- **Effect of attached notes.** Notes cut reposts and likes after attachment but less so views, and effects fade quickly if notes are slow [Slaughter25]. A large difference-in-differences study finds substantial reductions in spread once notes are shown, but also that notes often arrive too late to curb early virality [Nature26], whereas an earlier rollout study found no significant engagement reduction, plausibly because notes missed the early, most viral phase [Chuai24]. *We study the upstream question of whether and when notes get attached at all.*
- **Requests as a demand signal.** [Chuai26] analyze 98,685 requested posts and report that posts with higher estimated misleadingness are more likely to get notes, political posts less likely, and that the minority of requested posts receiving request-fostered notes from top contributors get notes rated more helpful and less polarized. [Pilarski26] compare fact-check supply and demand using about 1.1 million notes and requests from June 2024 to May 2025, find that requests target highly visible posts, and estimate with a quasi-experimental survival analysis that displaying requests

accelerates notes from Top Writers. [Gong26] relates request alerts to the diversity and visibility of notes. *We extend these with later data (to be confirmed), and replicate these findings on later data..*

- **Algorithm, partisanship, and consensus.** The bridging design is described in [Wojcik22]. [Allen22] show that partisanship strongly predicts whether users judge tweets misleading and whether they rate others' evaluations as helpful. *We separate failures from lack of attention from failures from disagreement, using rating counts and status history.*
- **What gets noted and what makes notes helpful.** [Pilarski24] studies how the crowd selects targets; [Solovev25] finds that citing unbiased sources raises helpfulness.
- **Coverage and speed at scale.** [DDIA25] reports low and falling English publication rates and long delays. *We extend through 2026 and add a formal decomposition of failure modes.*

3. Project Preparation and Data

Data (all public). From the official Community Notes download page [CNdata]: notes, ratings, noteStatusHistory, userEnrollment, and the note-request file. Identifiers are hashed. Sources:

1. **Current:** fresh dumps from X for 2025 to 2026. Third-party documentation indicates daily snapshots remain available for only about a week, so we will **download a full snapshot in week 1 and run a daily cron job** (e.g., cn_downloader.py from the community repo heruberuto/community-notes) to capture status changes over time. Community projects report the full data at roughly 45 GB, so we will load it into **DuckDB** (Parquet) rather than pandas.
2. **Historical (optional):** the Zenodo archive [Mohammadi25] adds detected language, extracted URLs, and topics for notes written January 2021 to January 2025, joinable by noteId.

Week-1 verification tasks (assumptions we have not yet confirmed):

- (a) exact schemas and timestamp columns in each file; in particular whether the request file has requester IDs and timestamps, is cumulative, and how far back it goes. Public request data was announced in May 2025, which would put our window largely after the period covered by [Pilarski26].
- (b) whether the data records when request alerts were shown to writers ([Pilarski26] report having to reconstruct this), and who is eligible to request (verified accounts per [Chuai26], but X's May 2025 announcement says verification is not required).
- (c) whether notes include a language field. If not, we run the main analysis without language splits.
- (d) whether X’s current notes and noteStatusHistory files reach back to 2021.

Tools: Python, DuckDB, pandas, lifelines (survival analysis), statsmodels.

Scope control. The unit of analysis is a post (tweetId) for RQ1 and a note (noteId) for RQ2. We observe only posts that received at least one request or note; posts nobody flagged are invisible, which we state as a limitation.

4. Methods and Evaluation

RQ1: Do requests still help?

Variables. For each post: number and timing of requests, time of first note, time of first CURRENTLY_RATED_HELPFUL status, and final status.

1. **Descriptives:** among posts with at least one request, the fraction that receive a note and a helpful note, by number of requests (1, 2-4, 5+).
2. **Time-to-event models:** Kaplan-Meier curves for time from first request to first note and to first helpful status, split by request count. Cox proportional-hazards model with covariates for creation month, request count, and language if available, with robust standard errors clustered by post. Posts with no note by the snapshot date are right-censored; we restrict to posts old enough (at least 14 days) to limit truncation bias.
3. **Replication check:** compare the direction and rough size of our estimates with [Pilarski26] for the earlier period, noting differences in data source and outcome definitions.
4. **Requester reliability:** if requester IDs are present, the share of each requester's requests that led to a note and to a helpful note, summarized as a distribution.

Because the public data does not show when alerts were displayed, we do not attempt a regression-discontinuity design and report adjusted associations rather than causal effects.

RQ2: Where do notes die?

Classify every note created at least 30 days before the snapshot into mutually exclusive fates, using noteStatusHistory and rating counts:

Fate	Definition
Under-rated	Needs more ratings, with fewer than the minimum rating count (5; confirm in the open-source scoring code)
Unresolved	Needs more ratings, despite reaching the minimum count (no cross-perspective agreement yet)
Rated not helpful	Currently rated not helpful
Published-then-removed	Reached helpful status, later lost it
Published	Currently rated helpful

Report fate shares by creation month (2021 to 2026) with 95% bootstrap confidence intervals. If a language field exists, also report English and Spanish separately for comparability with [DDIA25]. Secondary outcomes: time to the fifth rating and time to first helpful status, computed under two stated definitions of "time" (from post creation if available, and from note creation) to explain why prior estimates differ widely.

Validation

- **Reproduce published aggregates** as a sanity check (the roughly 90% never-published figure from [DDIA25] and, if language is available, English vs. Spanish trends). Large mismatches signal a pipeline error or a definitional difference we must explain.
- **Sensitivity analysis:** vary the minimum-age cutoffs (14/30/60 days) and the rating-count threshold.
- If we use a language detector, manually label 100 notes to check it.

Expected results and presentation

We expect (a) associations in RQ1 that are qualitatively consistent with [Pilarski26], with many low-value requests and (b) under-rating to account for most failures in recent data. A null result on RQ1 is informative for platform design. Figures: stacked bars of note fates by month; Kaplan-Meier curves by request count.

5. Timeline (5 weeks)

Week	Milestone
1	Download snapshot, start cron, verify schemas, read the three request papers, load into DuckDB
2	RQ2 pipeline and fate classification; validate against published numbers
3	RQ1 analysis (descriptives, survival models, replication check)
4	Sensitivity checks, figures
5	Write-up and video

6. Ethics

All data is public and pseudonymized, but note text can quote real people, so we will not redistribute raw note text and will report aggregates and short, non-identifying examples only. We will not attempt to re-identify contributors or requesters, and requester-level results will be reported only as distributions. Use of the data is governed by X's terms of service, which we will check. Sources of bias: (1) selection bias, since only posts users chose to flag are observed, and requested posts differ from others; (2) right-censoring and the rolling snapshot window; (3) if language is used, language-detection errors, likely worse for low-resource languages, which could misstate cross-language gaps; (4) the gap between "not published" and "wrong," since an unpublished note is not necessarily bad. If results were used to prioritize which requests or notes get surfaced, these biases could deprioritize under-served languages and topics, so we frame findings as descriptive, not as a tool for ranking or suppressing contributors.

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